

Knights of the Round Table: Knighthood in History and Medieval Arthurian Legend

by

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Introduction

The story of King Arthur is an incredibly well-known one-- even if one has never read a book on the legend, one is familiar with the general plot. Its ubiquity and its longevity is due in part to the fact that legends of King Arthur and his knights have been continuously written about since at least the tenth century, with evidence that places the story's origin even earlier as an oral tradition.¹ The legend of King Arthur and his knights have come to represent the Middle Ages to the modern reader.

King Arthur, in most interpretations, was the perfect king and the Britain he presided over was a magical kingdom populated with wizards and heroes. Geoffrey Chaucer, in his *Wife of Bath's Tale*, described Arthur as: "He whom the Britons hold in great honor."² In Medieval Europe, however, the legends largely focused on the knights rather than the titular king. Medieval authors like Marie de France and Chrétien de Troyes wrote almost exclusively about the members of the court, with Arthur himself appearing as a side character. These stories have survived for centuries, giving us an idea of who the knight was supposed to be. Fictional heroes like Lancelot and Gawain serve as a point of comparison to the kind of men they supposedly represented, that is the knights.

The purpose of this paper is to compare and contrast these fictional knights to their real-life counterparts living around the same time and place as when the legends were written. Primarily, this is in England and France from the mid-twelfth to the early fourteenth centuries. This paper will look at the ways the literature from this period created an ideal knight that, while

¹Barbara Harvey et al., *Short Oxford History of the British Isles: The Twelfth and Thirteenth Centuries* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001), 184.

² Geoffrey Chaucer, *The Canterbury Tales*, trans. David Wright, (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1985.) 240.

inspired by the knights living during this time, was very different. Furthermore, this paper will explore the influence this literature had on knights and their culture. The romanticized knight of medieval fiction has endured and distorted our modern view of knights and the middle ages as a whole. The goal of this research is to separate, at least in part, the legend from reality.

In order to address the differences between fictional and real knights, this paper will first discuss the historical reality of the archetypal knight. In this case, who were knights historically, what did they do, and what was their role in medieval society. While this is a broad topic and covers many centuries and an entire continent, for the sake of simplicity this paper will mainly focus on western Europe, namely England and France from the eleventh to the fourteenth centuries. It should be noted that because knighthood was so quintessentially European, it existed and spread across the continent. Once the concept of knighthood and what it meant to medieval Europe is clearer, it is easier to understand how Arthurian literature and romance literature in general developed from this culture.

Next, it is important to explain what we mean when we say Arthurian literature, which made up a large body of the chivalric literature popular among the knighthood. This chapter would explain the enduring popularity of Arthuriana, a term used to refer to writings and material related to legends of King Arthur. Arthur has appeared consistently in medieval sources dating back to at least the 9th century, if not earlier.³ Using these primary sources, it is possible to create a chronology for the Arthurian legend, from this first reference down to the 19th century. This chronology explains how the story developed over the medieval period and how Arthurian influence continues today. Academic debate on Arthur's influence in the medieval period and the historicity of the legend are part of this issue. Some historians have even

³ Howard Wiseman, "The Derivation of the Date of the Badon Entry in the *Annales Cambriae* from Bede and Gildas," *Parergon* 17, no. 2, (Jan 2000): 2, <https://doi.org/10.1353/pgn.2000.0072>.

suggested that King Arthur was a historical figure, a question which has been hotly debated since at least the 19th century.⁴ King Arthur, his knights especially, were important icons for the chivalric culture which dominated the knightly and noble classes of our period. Knights were the principal characters- and audience- of Arthurian literature, and to truly understand where the character of the knight comes from it is important to understand why Arthur was so important in the medieval period.

Finally, I will examine how the literature of the medieval period interprets and romanticizes the reality through the lens of Arthuriana as a nostalgic, fantastical setting. This would bring together the previous explanations of Arthuriana and knighthood that made up the earlier chapters. Really, this chapter is the core of the argument and brings the background information on knights as a class and Arthur as a character and influence together, through the core of romance. Romances were written by the *troubadours*, who either were knights or worked for knights, and they wanted to aggrandize knighthood to their audience, who were also knights.⁵ Additionally, the themes of courtly love and chivalry, which define the genre as a whole are important to this discussion. In this paper the actions and stories of Arthur's knights, as shown in medieval literature, will be compared to those of real knights. This will use works of romance from England and Northern France during the late 12th to mid 13th centuries. These sources will be used in direct comparison of monographs which focus on knights, as well as primary source documents relating to warfare and chivalry. These stories all presented supposedly ideal knights which strictly adhered to codes of chivalry and courtly love that, as we will see, were not followed by actual knights.

⁴ R.S. Loomis et al., *Arthurian Literature in the Middle Ages*, (Oxford: The Clarendon Press, 1959.) 1.

⁵ Nigel Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2011),179

In the course of my research, I used a wide variety of sources, both primary and secondary. Specifically I chose to focus on Arthurian literature from the late twelfth and thirteenth centuries. The most useful of these being Chretien de Troyes romances, though the *Lancelot-Grail Cycle* and *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* were also used. These books were helpful to my research focus on the knights rather than King Arthur himself. I also used secondary monographs which addressed knighthood and chivalric concepts. Several of these books, like Maurice Keen's *Chivalry*, became essential.

Fiction sparked my interest in history, and I believe that they can be used together to understand the past. Mythology and history are considered opposite subjects, one is by nature fiction and the other has an assumed veracity. However, mythology and indeed literature can serve as primary sources for the culture and time they come from. King Arthur was a part of what would today be considered pop culture, these stories reflected what the authors thought was important. Even things that are taken for granted in these romances, like court protocol and the fabrics of dresses described can teach the reader about life in the middle ages. I believe that because Arthuriana is so focused on a specific class, yet so widespread, it can provide a new perspective on knighthood in Medieval Europe.

Chapter 2

The image of the classic knight in shining armor is emblematic of the Middle Ages for many, but the brave, dashing gentleman in silvery armor defending damsels in distress is, to say the least, inaccurate. Knights in Romances, particularly Arthurian Romances, differed from real knights in four key ways: the way they fought, the duties expected of a knight by their lord, their relationship with the church, and most importantly their definitions of the term chivalry.

Chivalry is one of the most confusing aspects of knighthood yet it is inseparable from the identity of knights: “Chivalry may be described as an ethos in which martial, aristocratic and Christian elements were fused together.”⁶ For the historical knight, chivalry was simply a catch-all term for the culture of knights and their aristocratic lifestyle.⁷ This distinction is emblematic of the disparity between knights in fiction and knights in history, the real knights of medieval Europe were decidedly less fantastical, and certainly less romantic than our ideal.

Who is and isn’t a knight differs greatly throughout the middle ages and throughout Europe. In France, the prevailing term was the latin *miles* or *milites* literally translating to soldier.⁸ According to French medieval historian Georges Duby, “In the thirteenth century, a single latin word, *miles*, was always used to express membership of the coherent group already formed by the knighthood.”⁹ What began as a term to denote a career became a term denoting a particular noble class by the early 11th century: “Henceforth we find it [the word *miles*] used in two ways- either individually by men who displayed it as a personal title in the protocol at the

⁶ Maurice Keen, *Chivalry*, (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1984), 16. Ensure uniform type fonts

⁷ Sarah Douglas, “Knighthood as it Was, Not as We Wish it Were”, *Origins*, Miami and Ohio State History Departments. January 2011, Accessed Nov. 27, 2019. <https://origins.osu.edu/review/knighthood-it-was-not-we-wish-it-were>

⁸ “Charlton T. Lewis, “An Elementary Latin Dictionary.” Perseus Digital Library, Tufts University, accessed November 23, 2019.

<http://www.perseus.tufts.edu/hopper/text?doc=Perseus:text:1999.04.0060:entry=miles>.

⁹ Georges Duby, *The Chivalrous Society*, trans. Cynthia Postan (Berkeley: University of Chicago Press, 1977), 158.

beginning or end of charters, or collectively, to describe the particular rank of certain members of a court of justice or certain witnesses.”¹⁰

A similar term in Germany, *ministrals*, denoted a servile knight or vassal around the same time.¹¹ These knights were considered un-free, meaning that they were pledged to the lord and belonged to the household of their lord, similar to a serf, however this did not mean that they were poor or slaves as we would assume.¹² Throughout Europe, different terms came to be used to describe these fighting men, especially as they gained importance in their respective societies. However, there was one common thread amongst all these terms, that is the importance of warfare to the knight: “First, foremost, and always, the knight was a soldier: in Latin *miles*, in French *chevalier*, in German *Ritter*, Italian *cavaliere*, Spanish *caballero*, and in Anglo-Saxon *cnicht*.”¹³ One can assume that this anglo-saxon *cnicht* is where the modern English *knight* came from.¹⁴ Nonetheless, despite the variation among the names, these titles hold a common thread: every one of the terms described denotes a warrior on a horse.

But who precisely were these knights and what did they do? Knights were mounted warriors. .¹⁵ French medievalist Marc Bloch, defines a knight as a military vassal, or, more specifically “typically a man who served on horseback in heavy armour, and the function of the vassal consisted above all in fighting in this manner for his lord.”¹⁶ Medievalist Maruice Keen in his book *Chivalry* defines a knight as “a man of aristocratic standing and probably of noble

¹⁰ Duby, *The Chivalrous Society*, 159.

¹¹ Freed, John B. “Nobles, Ministerials, and Knights in the Archdiocese of Salzburg.” *Speculum* 62, no. 3 (Jul. 1987):576. doi:10.2307/2846383.

¹² Frances Gies, *The Knight in History* (New York: Harper and Row, 1984), 5.

¹³ “Knights.” In *Encyclopedia of Warrior Peoples & Fighting Groups*, ed. Paul K. Davis, and Allen Lee Hamilton, (Grey House Publishing, 2016.)
<http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/greywarrior/knights/0?institutionId=288>

¹⁴ Gies, *The Knight In History*, 3.

¹⁵ Marc Bloch, *Feudal Society*,, trans. L.A. Manyon (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1961), 290

¹⁶ Bloch, *Feudal Society*, 162

ancestry, who is capable, if called upon, of equipping himself with a warhorse and the arms of a heavy cavalryman, and who has been through certain rituals that made him what he is...”¹⁷ What is important here is the acknowledgement of nobility as a part of knighthood, because knights were noblemen.

Membership into this sort of military service required expensive equipment, which limited the kinds of people who became part of this mounted warrior group. By the 13th century, a war horse was worth five times the amount of a cow. “To be a cavalryman began to imply substantial means or substantial parentage.”¹⁸ In essence, to become a knight was expensive, making the occupation exclusive to noblemen who could afford it. Knights were invariably in service to a lord, who would call for their military service and loyalty. In exchange for the costly enterprise of knighthood, these warriors would be rewarded by their lords with gifts of land.¹⁹

This sort of interdependent relationship, known as vassalage, was the primary form of bond under the system of feudalism. Feudalism was a system based on interdependent relationships with an emphasis on land ownership and personal obligations.²⁰ Under this system, all knights were vassals, and as such occupied the upper levels of feudal society. Medieval historian Susan Reynolds defines vassalage as “the relation between a lord and his free or noble follower- his vassal. Because the vassal was a free man they see the relation, although unequal, as having had a voluntary and reciprocal quality that distinguished it significantly from that of a lord with his peasant tenants or subjects.”²¹ Under this relationship the vassal would provide

¹⁷ Keen, *Chivalry*, 1-2.

¹⁸ Keen, *Chivalry*, 26.

¹⁹ Bloch, *Feudal Society*, 158

²⁰ Bloch, *Feudal Society*, 446

²¹ Reynolds, *Fiefs and Vassals*, 17.

military service, or a payment called scutage if he's unable to meet this requirement, in exchange for payment in the form of land and protection.

In the 11th century, Bishop Fulbert of Chartres wrote a letter in which he explained the responsibilities of vassals to their lords: "He who swears fealty to his lord ought always to have these six things in memory; what is harmless, safe, honorable, useful, easy, practicable."²²

Vassals would provide aid and counsel to their lords by their martial services and attending the lord's court.²³ The main obligation of the lord to his knights was the granting of land, a system so successful that land held through vassalage was the main mode of land ownership through much of the middle ages.²⁴ The rewards of these lands became a mark of nobility as the fiefs were handed down to successors.²⁵ When these fiefs became hereditary, vassals gained a sense of security in their noble birth, this in turn created the aristocratic culture of knighthood.²⁶ Vassals would undertake an oath of fealty in which they swore under god, that is to say in public, to uphold their obligations to their lord and usually the lord and his vassal would kiss or clasp hands to demonstrate the amiability of the oath.²⁷

Warfare was the primary occupation of the knight and in literature, was the most important aspect of chivalry. Violence and warfare was the essential activity for the medieval man, it was also an affirmation of the knight's virility.²⁸ French knight Geoffroi de Charny in his treatise on chivalry discusses at length the importance of honoring knights who had fought in wars: "For it is from good battles that great honors arise and are increased, for good fighting men

²² "Fulbert of Chartres: On Feudal Obligations, 1020," Internet History Sourcebook, Fordham University, last modified October 15, 2019, <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/fulbert1.asp>

²³ Reynolds, *Fiefs and Vassals*, 19.

²⁴ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 11

²⁵ Reynolds, *Fiefs and Vassals*, 18.

²⁶ Reynolds, *Fiefs and Vassals*, 18.

²⁷ Rosenwein, *A Short History of the Middle Ages*, 132

²⁸ , Katherine Allen Smith "Saints in Shining Armor: Martial Asceticism and Masculine Models of Sanctity, Ca. 1050-1250." *Speculum* 83, no. 3 (Jul. 2008): 590. www.jstor.org/stable/20466282.

prove themselves in good battles, where they show their worth in their own locality without travelling outside it.”²⁹ Another example is King Richard I, known as Richard the Lion-Heart, in the Third Crusade is described as a hero throughout the account. “He, indeed, was emboldened by their fear. Letting his horse go, he charged swiftly at the enemy. He broke up the enemy's crowded battle line by charging through it.”³⁰ This account bears a striking resemblance to Arthurian romances of the same time. Chrétien de Troyes, a poet and author writing around the same time describes a Knight of the Round Table in battle very similarly. “His companions, likewise, showed largesse in the spilling of blood and brains and spent their blows freely.”³¹ There was, in fiction, an ideal representation of the knight in battle and it bled into historical account and the ethos of chivalry. In fiction, the knight was glorious and had a lust for bloodshed.

The reality of medieval warfare was less glorious. In fact for knights, it was fairly safe: armor was protective, pitched battles were avoided and knights made a genuine effort not to kill each other.³² For many knights, capturing the enemy for ransom was a means to make a living. Geoffroi de Charny even admonishes this practice in his treatise: “there are a number of men who pay more attention to taking prisoners and other profit, and when they have seized them and other winnings, they are more anxious to safeguard their captives and their booty than to help bring the battle to a good conclusion.”³³ A knight would be captured in battle, and his family

²⁹ Richard W. Kaeuper and Elspeth Kennedy, *The Book of Chivalry of Geoffroi de Charny*, 91.

³⁰ “*Itinerarium Peregrinorum et Gesta Regis Ricardi*: Richard the Lion-Hearted Conquers Cyprus, 1191 ” Internet History Sourcebook, Fordham University, last modified October 15, 2019, <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/1191cyprus.asp>

³¹ Chrétien De Troyes *Arthurian Romances*, trans. William W. Kibler and Carleton W. Carroll, (London: Penguin Books, 1991) 144

³² Keen, *Chivalry*, 220

³³ Kaeuper and Kennedy: *The Book of Chivalry*, 99.

would be expected to raise the ransom for his release.³⁴ Sometimes the high price of the ransom would be ruinous to the family.³⁵

Another pastime of the knight was tournaments. A tournament was a mock-battle, consisting of a melee of knights and usually jousting.³⁶ Tournaments hold pride of place in many of De Troyes' romances. In the romance *Cliges*, the titular knight shows his prowess at King Arthur's tournament, winning the favor of the king and his knights. "No sooner had he reached court than everyone ran out to greet him, making much ado over him and showing more happiness at his coming than had ever before been seen, and all those who had been captured by him at the tournament addressed him as lord."³⁷ Charny says that knights could build a reputation and wealth for themselves through tournaments.³⁸

This is exactly what one William Marshal, a knight, nobleman and later regent of England who was referred to as the flower of chivalry, did.³⁹ A younger son of John the Marshal, a lesser nobleman, he grew up during a period of civil war in eleventh century England called the Anarchy.⁴⁰ "If William did not mourn his father, it is not that he reproached him for having sent him out of the house virtually empty-handed."⁴¹ William was then taken in by a relative and trained to become a knight, eventually being knighted right before being sent off into the Battle of Drincourt.⁴² "He had no sooner left the Tancarville household than he was already tourneying and winning."⁴³ His prowess brought him to the attention of Eleanor of Aquitaine,

³⁴ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 31

³⁵ Keen, *Chivalry*, 221

³⁶ Gies, *The Knight in History* 31

³⁷ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 184

³⁸ Kaeuper and Kennedy: *The Book of Chivalry*, 87.

³⁹ Georges Duby, *William Marshal: The Flower of Chivalry*, trans. Richard Howard. (New York: Pantheon Books, 1986), 26

⁴⁰ Jessie Crosland, *William the Marshal: The Last Great Feudal Baron* (London: Peter Owen Ltd, 1962), 19.

⁴¹ Duby, *William Marshal*, 67

⁴² Crosland, *William the Marshal*, 24

⁴³ Duby, *William Marshal*, 73

queen to Henry II, and became one of the chief knights of his household as well as tutor to his son, the heir.⁴⁴ By the time of his death at the age of seventy, he was the Earl of Pembroke and regent to Henry III.⁴⁵ His martial prowess in tournaments established him as a capable knight and caught the attention of the ruler who would become his patron, much like in the story of Cliges.

Tournaments were more than ostentatious displays of wealth and entertainment. They were part of a ritual of courtly manners and a way for knights to build their reputation. The medieval tournament was a successor to the judicial duel, a form of trial by combat that was later replaced by the jury system, and ceremony.⁴⁶ Knights could resolve conflicts or feuds through these tournaments, settling disputes by combat was a means of placing the verdict in God's hands.⁴⁷ Take for example the treatise on organizing a tournament written by Rene of Anjou in 1460. While this is a much later text, it does show the degree of ceremony involved in these events. Another example is the method of invitation presented in the beginning of the text: "the aforesaid prince ought first to send secretly to the prince to whom he wishes to present the sword, to find out whether or not he intends to accept, and in order to arrange the appropriate public ceremonies if he wishes to accept."⁴⁸ The pomp and ceremony of tournaments was later used to emulate the Arthurian court. In 1284, King Edward I hosted a "round table" tournament, where knights from all over Europe fought and he was presented the crown of King Arthur.⁴⁹

The medieval lady is a character as complex as her knight, in part because so little was written about her beyond fiction. The term lady is used to refer to a noblewoman, in order to

⁴⁴ Keen, *Chivalry*, 20

⁴⁵ Keen, *Chivalry*, 21.

⁴⁶ Keen, *Chivalry*, 204.

⁴⁷ , Jacqueline Stuhmiller, "Iudicium Dei, Iudicium Fortunae": Trial by Combat in Malory's "Le Morte Darthur". *Speculum* 81, no. 2 (2006): 427-62. www.jstor.org/stable/20463717.

⁴⁸ Elizabeth Bennet, "King René's Tournament Book." Princeton University. Last modified September 4, 1998. <http://www.princeton.edu/~ezb/rene/renehome.html#book>.

⁴⁹ Ruth Huff Cline, "The Influence of Romances on Tournaments of the Middle Ages." *Speculum* 20, no. 2 (1945): 204-11. doi:10.2307/2854595.

contrast the experiences of the noblemen that constitute the knightly class. In romances of the day, the lady was quiet and at the mercy of her knight. In the *Lais of Marie de France*, women are rarely, if ever, named characters. *Lanval*, one of the *lais*, features a knight of the round table who is rescued twice by his lady love, however Guinevere is the only named female character.⁵⁰ In Arthurian literature, women are painted as helpless and this was justification for violence against them. In *The Knight of the Cart*, de Troyes says that a knight must protect the lady he is escorting. "But if she were being escorted by another, and the knight chose to do battle with her defender and defeated him at arms, then he might do with her as he pleased without incurring dishonor or disgrace."⁵¹ However, medieval women were not completely helpless: the letters of Margaret Paston to her husband detail her preparations to defend her home. In one letter from 1448 she says: "Right worshipful husband, I recommend me to you, and pray you to get some crossbows and windases to bend them with, and quarrels [that is bolts fired by crossbows]..." "As the Medieval period went on, women progressively lost their independence, their place in the public eye and economic opportunity lessened as time went on."⁵²

The Arthurian tradition is also obsessed with marriage. The romance *Erec et Enide* focuses on a married couple and shows a wife balancing her love and concern for her husband with avoiding violence at his hands. Erec blames his wife for the lapse in his chivalric reputation and sets out on a quest to punish her for it.⁵³ In the middle ages, marriage was about economics, particularly for the nobility who also sought to increase or preserve their family's standing.

⁵⁰ Marie de France, *The Lais of Marie de France* trans. Glyn S. Burgess and Keith Busby, (London: Penguin Books, 1986), 73-81

⁵¹ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 173.

⁵² Susan Mosher Stuard, "Introduction," in *Women in Medieval Society*, ed. Susan Mosher Stuard (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1976), 9.

⁵³ Kathryn Gravdal, "Chrétien De Troyes, Gratian, and the Medieval Romance of Sexual Violence." *Signs* 17, no. 3 (1992): 572 www.jstor.org/stable/3174623.

According to Georges Duby: “this meant giving away their daughters and negotiating as best they could their daughters’ reproductive potential and the advantages which they were supposed to endow their off-spring.”⁵⁴ Medieval marriage focused on the submission of the wife, and discussions on the topic were written by men, for men and had “three precepts: monogamy, exogamy and the repression of pleasure.”⁵⁵

Arthurian romance was obsessed with courtly love, that is, a code for noblemen and women to supposedly abide by in order to love well. A major treatise on the subject, written by Chretien De Troyes contemporary, Andreas Cappellanus, is *Art of Courtly Love*, adapted from Ovid. Cappellanus asserts that love is suffering, and must be kept a secret because love only exists outside of marriage.⁵⁶ “The lover and his lady are no longer playing a game of mutual deceit. She is now his feudal suzerain, and he owes allegiance to her, or to Cupid through her. Her status is far above his...”⁵⁷ In Arthuriana, this language is strong: “One who loves totally is ever obedient, and willingly and completely does whatever might please his sweetheart. And so Lancelot, who loved more than Pyramus...must do her bidding.”⁵⁸

Courtly love made adultery permissible in literature, and Lancelot and Guinevere’s affair is a famous example of that. In reality, adultery was not accepted. Husbands and wives owed each other sexual relations as part of the contract of marriage; Pope Innocent III once said in a letter that “Nonetheless if the wife refuses to obey because she fears to lapse from chastity, her

⁵⁴ Georges Duby, *Love and Marriage in the Middle Ages*, trans. Jane Dunnet, (Chicago: University of Chicago Press), 7

⁵⁵ Georges Duby *The Knight, The Lady and The Priest: The Making of Modern Marriage in Medieval France*, trans. Barbara Bray. (New York: Pantheon Books, 1983), 31

⁵⁶ Andreas Cappellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, trans. John Jay Parry, (New York: Columbia University Press, 1990), 6, 28.

⁵⁷ Cappellanus, *Courtly Love*, 8

⁵⁸ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 254

husband may and ought render the conjugal debt to her with the fear of the Lord.”⁵⁹ It was of utmost importance that unmarried women be virgins and protected against any sexual liberties.⁶⁰

The knight and the lady are two archetypal characters of the medieval romance genre. The real knights and ladies who inspired these characters lived much more complicated lives than in the stories. Knights, that is the noble mounted warrior class of vassals, were balancing their feudal obligations of warfare with the Christian world around them. The identity of knighthood was developing along with the Medieval world, but was defined by its violence and nobility. The knight and the lady were people whose lives were defined by their submission, the lady to her father and her husband and the knight to the feudal lord.

⁵⁹ “Innocent III: Letters on Marriage, and Women ” Internet History Sourcebook, Fordham University, last modified October 15, 2019. <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/innIII-marriagewomen.asp>

⁶⁰ Phillips, *Medieval Maidens*, 167.

Chapter 3

The stories of King Arthur and his court were created over centuries by writers who used mythology and history to make their own creations.⁶¹ According to author Rodney Castleden, King Arthur has been reimagined through the lens of different authors and has emerged very differently in these tales.⁶² Even though his knights were most prominent,, the King was the most integral part of the Arthurian legend. King Arthur and Camelot are synonymous with the Middle Ages and have been featured in almost every form of media, from animation to advertisements. For many, Walt Disney's 1963 film, *The Sword in the Stone*, was the first and most significant interpretation of the legend.⁶³ This film was loosely based on T.H. White's 1958 book *The Once and Future King*, rather than medieval source material.⁶⁴

By the time White was writing, the character of Arthur and much of the general plot had been consistent since the 15th century. This is largely due to Sir Thomas Malory's *Le Mort D'arthur*, a book written in 1485 that unified a jumbled and very old Arthurian tradition into a single text. It had survived because it comprehensively but compactly told the entire tradition in one narrative.⁶⁵ According to Malory, Arthur was the legendary king of Britain, and his court

⁶¹ A. E. Redgate, "Arthur." In *The Oxford Companion to British History*, edited by John Cannon, and Robert Crowcroft. 2nd ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015).
<http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/oupoxford/arthur/0?institutionId=288>

⁶² Rodney Castleden, *King Arthur: The Truth Behind the Legend*, (Routledge Books, London: 2002), 1.

⁶³ Michael Torregrossa, "Merlin Goes to the Movies: The Changing Role of Merlin in Cinema Arthuriana." *Film & History* 29, no. 3-4 (1999): 54.
<http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.proquest.com/docview/2148492?accountid=14171>.

⁶⁴ Kevin J. Harty, "CINEMA ARTHURIANA: TRANSLATIONS OF THE ARTHURIAN LEGEND TO THE SCREEN." *Arthurian Interpretations* 2, no. 1 (1987): 103. Accessed February 5, 2020.
[www.jstor.org/stable/27868632](http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/cupliteng/morte_darthur_le/0?institutionId=288).

⁶⁵ "Morte Darthur, Le." In *The Cambridge Guide to Literature in English*, ed. by Ian Ousby. 2nd ed. (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2000.)
http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/cupliteng/morte_darthur_le/0?institutionId=288

was filled by a circle of knights who sat at a round table in his castle Camelot. In *Le Mort D'arthur* Arthur becomes king of Britain when he “lightly and fiercely” pulls an enchanted sword from a stone put in place by the wizard Merlin.⁶⁶ King Arthur filled his court with many knights, the most famous of which is Lancelot du Lac, who is described in the text as the “noblest knight living.”⁶⁷ Lancelot has an affair with Queen Guinevere, King Arthur’s wife, which fractures the knights and brings about King Arthur’s downfall. In the final battle, Arthur is killed by his nephew and sometimes son, Sir Mordred.⁶⁸

. Because the Arthurian legend has been retold in so many different ways over such a long period of time, one may wonder about the story’s origins, and in fact some have wondered whether King Arthur had a basis in history. Stories about King Arthur started throughout the British Isles since the 9th century, though some speculate even earlier, in the 6th century⁶⁹ One of the first places he appears is in the Battle of Badon, which appears in many of the earliest records. A mid-fifth century monk and historian named Gildas wrote the only contemporary account of the Anglo-Saxon invasions.⁷⁰ Gildas goes into detail in his description of the battle between the Saxons and the Britons, led by Arthur, partly because he was born in the same year and witnesses were supposedly available.⁷¹ However, Gildas doesn’t mention Arthur by name in his account of this battle, which is unusual as his work was very emphatic regarding the failings of the Britons and their kings. According to one expert, “Gildas does not say who the British commander was, or whether the British were besiegers or besieged. No doubt that was partly

⁶⁶ Thomas Malory, *Le Mort D'arthur*, (New York: Race Point Publishing, 2017), 7.

⁶⁷ Malory, *Le Morte D'arthur*, 106.

⁶⁸ Amy Varin, "Mordred, King Arthur's Son." *Folklore* 90, no. 2 (1979): 167-77. Accessed January 17, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/1259595.

⁶⁹ Howard Wiseman, “The Derivation of the Date of the Badon Entry in the *Annales Cambriae* from Bede and Gildas,” *Parergon* 17, no. 2, (Jan 2000): 2, <https://doi.org/10.1353/pgn.2000.0072>.

⁷⁰ E.A. Thompson, “Gildas and the History of Britain,” *Britannia* 10, (1979)

⁷¹ J.C. Russel, “Arthur and the Romano-Celtic Frontier” *Modern Philology* 48, no. 3 (Feb. 1951), 148.

because his deepest convictions are already decided by God, so historical facts were not very important.”⁷²

Arthur is first definitively named as a participant in The Battle of Badon in the *Annales Cambriae*, a 13th century Welsh history, possibly written in the fifth century.⁷³ Arthur only appears in two lines of the record, which don’t reveal much about Arthur or where he came from, and doesn’t even refer to him as a king.. The chronicle says that in 516 someone named Arthur carried the cross at the Battle of Badon: “The Battle of Badon, in which Arthur carried the Cross of our Lord Jesus Christ for three days and three nights on his shoulders and the Britons were the victors.”⁷⁴ The next entry, dated to about 537, is just as vague: “The battle of Camlann, in which Arthur and Medraut [Mordred] fell: and there was plague in Britain and Ireland.”⁷⁵

The king’s career is first discussed in greater depth in *Historia Brittonum*, a book written around 828 that is often attributed to Nennius, a Welsh monk.⁷⁶ While some of the book has a historical basis, its references to dragons and its poetic style put the reliability of the text into question; because of the scarcity of sources from that period, the book is still useful according to Castleden.⁷⁷ *Historia Brittonum* offers a series of battles Arthur supposedly fought against the Saxons, with the Battle of Badon being the twelfth.⁷⁸ Interestingly, Nennius refers to Arthur as *dux bellorum*, a Latin term for war leader, which can also be used to describe a king.⁷⁹

⁷² P.J.C. Field, “Arthur’s Battles,” *Arthuriana* 18, no. 4 (2008), 4.

⁷³ Howard Wiseman, “The Derivation of the Date of the Badon Entry,” 1.

⁷⁴ “*Annales Cambriae*,” Internet History Sourcebook, Fordham University, accessed Jan 10, 2019, <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/annalescambriae.asp>.

⁷⁵ Internet History Sourcebook, “*Annales Cambriae*.”

⁷⁶ N.J. Higham, *King Arthur: Myth-Making and History*, (London: Routledge Books, 2000), 10.

⁷⁷ Castleden, *King Arthur: The Truth Behind the Legend*, 17.

⁷⁸ John Moris, trans. “Excerpt from Nennius’ *Historia Britonum*, Arthur’s Battles Against the Saxons.” Project Camelot, Rochester University, 1980. Accessed Dec. 30, 2020, <https://d.lib.rochester.edu/camelot/text/arthurs-battles-against-the-saxons>.

⁷⁹ Edward Donald Kennedy et al., *King Arthur: A Casebook*, (New York: Garland Publishing, 1996) 29.

From the twelfth century onwards, Arthurian legend became more prominent in English writing. Part of this can be attributed to Geoffrey of Monmouth, and his work, *History of the Kings of Britain*, written around 1136.⁸⁰ Monmouth's contemporaries and modern readers acknowledge that some of the literary sources referenced in *The History of the Kings of Britain* were invented by Monmouth.⁸¹ For example, Monmouth references what he calls a "very ancient book" but he never divulges the author or the title of the account which serves as his main source for Arthur.⁸² Monmouth introduced or referenced many elements of the legend, including Arthur's Excalibur, which he calls Caliburn; Arthur's status as a king; the Isle of Avalon; and Arthur's eventual resurrection, which drew from pre-existing Celtic traditions at the time.⁸³ Another notable addition to the legend by Monmouth is the figure of Merlin, who appears to provide assistance to various British kings in Monmouth's *History*.⁸⁴ Historian Rodney Castleden said of the wizard, "Merlin comes across as a magical semi-pagan figure, while Arthur is a Christian hero."⁸⁵ King Arthur's treatment in Monmouth's writing is one of the most complete, taking up chapters as opposed to the two lines seen in the *Annales Cambriae*. Arthurian expert Geoffrey Ashe calls this a "flowering of the legend."⁸⁶

Some experts have said Monmouth's *History* was a reaction to the aftermath of various invasions of Britain, but depending on the source, it was either in support of or in opposition to

⁸⁰ Geoffrey Ashe, "'A Certain Very Ancient Book': Traces of an Arthurian Source in Geoffrey of Monmouth's History." *Speculum* 56, no. 2 (1981): 301. Accessed February 12, 2020. doi:10.2307/2846937.

⁸¹ D. R. Howlett, "The Literary Context of Geoffrey of Monmouth: An Essay on the Fabrication of Sources," *Arthuriana* 5, no. 3 (1995): 66. Accessed January 16, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/27869123.

⁸² Ashe, "'A Certain Very Ancient Book'", 301.

⁸³ Victoria Flood, "Arthur's Return to Avalon: Geoffrey of Monmouth and the Development of the Legend," *Arthuriana* 25, no. 2 (2015), 85 accessed Jan. 10, 2020, www.jstor.org/stable/24643472.

⁸⁴ Lucy Allen Paton, "Notes on Merlin in the 'Historia Regum Britanniae' of Geoffrey of Monmouth." *Modern Philology* 41, no. 2 (1943), 90. Accessed Jan. 8, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/433972.

⁸⁵ Castleden, *King Arthur*, 34.

⁸⁶ Ashe, "'A Certain Very Ancient Book'", 323.

the threat of colonization looming over Wales in the early 12th century.⁸⁷ According to medievalist Barbara Harvey, “In 1136, at about the time Geoffrey was writing his *History*, the Welsh were seizing the chance offered by the death of Henry I to shake off the rule he had imposed upon them.”⁸⁸ There are many interpretations of Monmouth’s *History*. Some have argued it is an appeal to the Anglo-Norman rulers for unity, or an “illustrious genealogy” of these rulers, or even to express Monmouth’s Breton or Welsh sympathies.⁸⁹ Those who argue in favor of Monmouth’s book as a pro-Welsh history argue that Monmouth was a Breton patriot who promoted, as medievalist Michael Faletra put it, a “pan-Celtic alliance” by glorifying the Bretons of the ancient past and by extension the Welsh.⁹⁰ Monmouth used Welsh influences and legends to help write his Arthur, and according to medieval literature expert Victoria Flood, intended for his vision of Arthur to serve as a symbol for the Welsh.⁹¹ However, Arthur became a symbol of the Anglo-Norman monarchy.⁹² Henry II in particular associated himself with the Arthurian tradition: he wanted to compare himself to Arthur, who had complete dominion over Britain, to justify his control of the island.⁹³ Henry II was so interested in the legend that he searched for Arthur’s supposed tomb in Glastonbury Abbey.⁹⁴

⁸⁷ Higham, *King Arthur*, 218.

⁸⁸ Barbara F Harvey, *The Twelfth and Thirteenth Centuries: 1066-C.1280*. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011), 184.

⁸⁹ Paul Dalton, “The Topical Concerns of Geoffrey of Monmouth’s *Historia Regum Britannie*: History, Prophecy, Peacemaking, and English Identity in the Twelfth Century.” *Journal of British Studies* 44, no. 4 (2005): 689.

⁹⁰ Michael A. Faletra, “Narrating the Matter of Britain: Geoffrey of Monmouth and the Norman Colonization of Wales.” *The Chaucer Review* 35, no. 1 (2000): 61.

⁹¹ Flood, “Arthur’s Return to Avalon,” 84-86.

⁹² Nicholas Vincent, “HENRY II.” *History Today*, 12, (2004). 47.

⁹³ <http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.proquest.com/docview/202816753?accountid=14171>.

⁹⁴ Vincent, “Henry II,” 47.

⁹⁴ Harvey, *The Twelfth and Thirteenth Centuries*, 184.

The History of the Kings of Britain marked an important development in Arthuriana as Arthur became less a historical character and more of a literary figure. The twelfth century saw a proliferation of Arthurian texts. Robert Wace's *Roman de Brut*, written around the 1150's, was an elaborate French translation of Monmouth's *History*, and introduced the now famous Round Table.⁹⁵ Wace's Arthur was aligned with the French ideals of chivalry; this Arthur was, as historian Frances Gies puts it, "the paragon of knighthood, in the tradition of the romances."⁹⁶ Arthur became a part of a larger trend in medieval literature: the burgeoning genre of Romance which made medieval literature increasingly secular. Romances, which originally meant poems written in French rather than Latin, was the genre of poetry concerning courtly manners and chivalric culture.⁹⁷ According to literary scholar Eugene Vinaver, "Love interest and the pursuit of adventures unrelated to any common aim thus displaced the theme of the defence of Christendom and the preoccupation with feudal warfare."⁹⁸ In this new genre, Arthur also changed. King Arthur was pushed into the background as the focus of the Arthurian canon now shifted to the knights.⁹⁹ This is not surprising considering that the troubadours who wrote these romances were either knights themselves or worked in their service.¹⁰⁰ This shift was finalized in the work of French poet Chretien de Troyes, who wrote around the 1170's. His five romances: *Erec et Enide*, *Cliges*, *Lancelot or the Knight of the Cart*, *Yvain* and *Perceval*, all featured a different knight of Arthur's court rather than the king himself.

⁹⁵ Harvey, *The Twelfth and Thirteenth Centuries*, 187.

⁹⁶ Gies, *The Knight in History*, , 75.

⁹⁷ Jay Ruud, "medieval romance." In *Encyclopedia of Medieval Literature*, by Jay Ruud. 2nd ed. Facts On File, 2014. http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/fof/medieval/medieval_romance/0?institutionId=288

⁹⁸ Eugene Vinaver, *The Rise of Romance* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1971,) 1.

⁹⁹ Kennedy et al. *King Arthur: A Casebook*, 29.

¹⁰⁰ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 49.

Chretien de Troyes added the character of Lancelot, as well as his affair with Guinevere, who had been briefly referenced in Monmouth's *History*. By the end of the 12th century they became integral parts of the legend.¹⁰¹ The romances represented many aspects of the secular knightly lifestyle from tournaments to heraldry.¹⁰² De Troyes' Lancelot was, like Wace's Arthur, the exemplar of knighthood, as were all of the knights-errant in De Troyes' poetry, according to the author. He seemed eager to instruct readers to follow in his protagonists' examples, with characters going on lengthy, edifying asides on the nature of love and courtesy.¹⁰³ Courtly love and chivalry were introduced through the 12th century romances purely as a literary ideal.¹⁰⁴ Romance literature dominated the Arthurian canon for the rest of the medieval period, ultimately compiled in Malory's *Le Morte D'arthur* in 1485.

By the time Malory was writing, in the later 15th century, Arthuriana had been around for centuries and left a mark on medieval culture. This impact was perhaps most strongly felt among the knights, who wanted to emulate the prestige of knights in romances, through pageantry and writing.¹⁰⁵ For example, Arnold de Guine, an early 13th century Flemish nobleman and lord, called upon the Arthurian tradition in the chronicle of his life, even requesting to be trained by Phillip of Flanders, who was praised by Chretien de Troyes himself in his romance *Perceval*.¹⁰⁶ Chretien says of Flanders: "Count Philip of Flanders, who surpasses Alexander, whom they say was so great."¹⁰⁷ The fact that Arnold de Guine sought to learn under Philip of Flanders after the book was written speaks to the reputation of Arthurian literature. The romances made

¹⁰¹ Lori J. Walters *et al.*, *Lancelot and Guinevere: A Casebook*, (New York: Garland Publishing, 1996), 3.

¹⁰² Keen, *Chivalry*, 91,135.

¹⁰³ Sidney Painter, *French Chivalry*, (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1964), 131.

¹⁰⁴ Vinaver, *The Rise of Romance*, 32.

¹⁰⁵ Keen, *Chivalry*, 200.

¹⁰⁶ Keen, *Chivalry*, 19.

¹⁰⁷ Chretien De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances* (London: Penguin Books, 1991), 381.

knighthood glamorous; even King Henry II wanted to emulate Lancelot by asking for the King of Scotland to knight him.¹⁰⁸

Arthuriana had seeped into tournaments, which became known as round tables, that copied the pageantry of those in the fictional Camelot.¹⁰⁹ One 1279 round table had about one hundred damsels and one hundred knights riding to the grounds while singing.¹¹⁰ Arthurian romance often uses the tournament as a theme, as it did in de Troyes' romances. Beginning in the 13th century, the nobility was using fantasy as inspiration for tournaments; Edward I in 1284 had participants take on Arthurian roles during the games.¹¹¹

In the Middle Ages, King Arthur and Camelot were glorified and were a patriotic symbol of England and its rulers.¹¹² Fiction often serves as a representation of culture, as historian Erich S. Gruen aptly puts it: "people strove to articulate their special qualities with reference to the dominant [culture]..."¹¹³ In the early 12th century the newly minted Norman rulers of England were looking for a past to hold onto; *The History of the Kings of Britain* fulfilled this need by tracing English history back to its legendary ancient origins, all the way back to the Trojan War.¹¹⁴ According to Higham, Arthuriana "provided the new Anglo-Norman kings with a predecessor of heroic size, a great pan-British king in a long line of monarchs capable of

¹⁰⁸ Keen, *Chivalry*, 68.

¹⁰⁹ Ruth Huff Kline, "The Influence of Romances on Tournaments of the Middle Ages." *Speculum* 20, no. 2 (1945), 204.

¹¹⁰ Huff Cline, "The Influence of Romances on Tournaments of the Middle Ages," 407.

¹¹¹ Phillip E. Bennet, Sara Carpenter and Louise Gardiner, "CHIVALRIC GAMES AT THE COURT OF EDWARD III: THE JOUSTING LETTERS OF EUL MS 183." *Medium Aevum* 87, no. 2 (2018), 308, <http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.proquest.com/docview/2326815657?accountid=14171>.

¹¹² Beate Schmolke-Hasslemann, *The Evolution of Arthurian Romance: The Verse Tradition from Chretien to Froissart*, (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 285.

¹¹³ Erich S. Gruen, "Cultural Fictions and Cultural Identity." *Transactions of the American Philological Association* (1974-) 123 (1993): 14. doi:10.2307/284321.

¹¹⁴ Maureen Fries, "The Arthurian Moment: History and Geoffrey of Monmouth's "Historia Regum Britannie"." *Arthuriana* 8, no. 4 (1998), 90.. www.jstor.org/stable/27869401.

countering contemporary pressures for decentralization, as had occurred in France, and reinforcing claims of political superiority over the Celtic lands.”¹¹⁵.

Some scholars have argued for the existence of a real, historical King Arthur. Much of this argument is built on the appearance of Arthur in a series of sometimes dubious, historical accounts.. R.S. Loomis, one of the foremost authorities on Arthurian literature, said “there is a certain amount of early material dealing with him, but the difficulty lies in distinguishing what is, if anything, history from what is legend.”¹¹⁶ According to some, sources such as the *Annales Cambriae*, Gildas and Nennius are an earnest attempt to record history, which supposes the actual existence of the legendary king.¹¹⁷ Historians in favor of the existence of a historical Arthur have pieced together a theory on his identity: a military leader who lived in the sixth century during the Anglo Saxon invasions.¹¹⁸ Medievalist Kemp Malone argued that perhaps the historical Arthur lived earlier, and wasn’t even British; in his 1925 book he pointed to a second century Roman commander, Lucius Artorius Castus, as a historical prototype for Arthur.¹¹⁹ In the century that Arthur supposedly lived, there was an increase in the name Arthur in records from the Celtic regions of the British Isles, suggesting the presence of a figure these people were named after, as noted by linguist Kenneth Hurlstone Jackson.¹²⁰ There is no conclusive evidence as to whether Arthur existed, because of the breadth of representations of Arthur and a lack of

¹¹⁵ Higham, *King Arthur*, 223.

¹¹⁶ R.S. Loomis et al., *Arthurian Literature in the Middle Ages*, (Oxford: The Clarendon Press, 1959.) 1.

¹¹⁷ Field, “Arthur’s Battles”, 21.

¹¹⁸ Mary Williams “King Arthur in History and Legend,” *Folklore* 73, no. 2 (1962), 73. Accessed January 20, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/1258608.

¹¹⁹ Higham, *King Arthur*, 12.

¹²⁰ Loomis et al., *Arthurian Literature in the Middle Ages*, 3.

contemporary records.¹²¹ Higham says that, “The likeliest origin was a military leader of repute in Roman Britain who had become legendary...”¹²²

The 19th century saw a rediscovery of Arthuriana, as well as all things medieval, as a source of symbolism.¹²³ King Arthur was used to express ideas of England's past, as well as to present certain aspects as an ideal of English identity such as virility and Christian faith.¹²⁴ The Pre-Raphaelite art movement of the 19th century reinvigorated interest in the Middle Ages, and Arthur especially.¹²⁵ The Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood was a group of artists that wanted to return to the “moral and descriptive truthfulness” they felt characterized art before the renaissance, that is, medieval art.¹²⁶ They were especially concerned with narrative in their paintings, with scenes from Shakespeare and contemporary poetry dominating their paintings.¹²⁷ This renewed attention to medieval themes was reflected in the works of writers and historians of the 19th and early 20th centuries. Mark Twain's *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* and T.H. White's *The Once and Future King*, the basis of Disney's *Sword in the Stone*, demonstrated this continued popularity.

According to Arthurian experts Beverly Taylor and Elisabeth Brewer, “despite an external and internal landscape apparently hostile to romance, Arthur returned to English

¹²¹ Geoffrey Ashe, "The Origins of the Arthurian Legend." *Arthuriana* 5, no. 3 (1995), 1. Accessed January 21, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/27869122.

¹²² Higham, *King Arthur*, 97.

¹²³ Beverly Taylor, and Elisabeth Brewer. *The Return of King Arthur: British and American Arthurian Literature since 1900*. Suffolk, (UK: Boydell and Brewer Limited, 1983), 1.

¹²⁴ Stephanie L. Barczewski, *Myth and National Identity in Nineteenth Century Britain: The Legends of King Arthur and Robin Hood*. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000.), 2.

¹²⁵ Inga Bryden, "All Dressed Up: Revivalism and the Fashion for Arthur in Victorian Culture." *Arthuriana* 21, no. 2 (2011): 33. Accessed March 17, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/23238239.

¹²⁶ "Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood." In *The Thames & Hudson Dictionary of British Art*, ed. by David Bindman, and Nigel J. Morgan. (London: Thames & Hudson, 1988.) http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/thba/pre_raphaelite_brotherhood/0?institutionId=288

¹²⁷ "Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood." In *The Thames & Hudson Dictionary of British Art*.

literature after more than three hundred years with an intensity remarkable for both the quality and quantity of works produced.”¹²⁸ In fact, this period saw much scholarly debate on the historicity of Arthur; in the beginning of the Victorian period, much of the debate was wrapped up in ideas of Anglo-Saxon superiority.¹²⁹ “After the Second World War, the British King Arthur who had famously triumphed over Germanic invaders in the Dark Ages was widely, but not always consciously, reconstructed as a historical icon for post-war British society.”¹³⁰ As late as 1997, Scottish politicians recreated Arthur’s famous sword in the stone as a means to express Britishness During the United Kingdom General Election ¹³¹

To the modern reader, Arthur has come to represent not only British ideals but also the medieval period as a whole. Through Arthuriana, the Middle Ages are both a far away time, yet accessible to the imagination of the viewer.¹³² Arthuriana evokes a nostalgia that idealizes the past with modern longings and values.¹³³ The legend of King Arthur is still incredibly popular, and has been reimagined in musicals such as *Camelot*, television shows such as BBC’s *Merlin* and loosely in Marvel Comics superhero title *Excalibur*. Arthur has come a long way from his first mention in the *Annales Cambriae*.¹³⁴ The continued popularity of Arthur could be explained simply in its reinvention, but it is still familiar and nostalgic despite reimagining, using the same symbols and scenes to communicate new messages than the work before.¹³⁵ Arthuriana survives centuries because it is reinvented, with authors using the tradition in new ways to communicate

¹²⁸ Taylor and Brewer, *The Return of King Arthur*, 15.

¹²⁹ Higham, *King Arthur*, 10

¹³⁰ Higham, *King Arthur*, 36

¹³¹ MacColl “King Arthur and the Making of an English Britain,” 7.

¹³² Leah Haught, “Performing Nostalgia: Medievalism in “King Arthur” and “Camelot.”” *Arthuriana* 24, no. 4 (2014), 121.

¹³³ Helen Dell, “Nostalgia and Medievalism: Conversations, Contradictions, Impasses.” *Postmedieval* 2, no. 2 (Summer, 2011), 116.

¹³⁴ Castleden, *King Arthur*, 3.

¹³⁵ Lorraine K. Stock, “Reinventing an Iconic Arthurian Moment: The Sword in the Stone in Films and Television.” *Arthuriana* 25, no. 4 (2015): 67.

new meanings.¹³⁶ As Arthurian expert Dan Nastali notes: “every Arthurian work represents, to some degree, a personal response to the received material, and each work reinvigorates the tradition, for better or for worse, by placing before the public yet another object to respond to.”¹³⁷

¹³⁶ Michael W. George, "Arthuriana as Living Tradition." *Arthuriana* 15, no. 4 (2005) ,15.

¹³⁷ Dan Nastali, and Phil Boardman. "Searching for Arthur: Literary Highways, Electronic Byways, and Cultural Back Roads." *Arthuriana* 11, no. 4 (2001), 120.

Chapter 4

In the later middle ages, romances became one of the most popular types of secular literature among the upper classes.¹³⁸ A narrative poem with aristocratic characters engaging in combat and/or love affairs, written in a vernacular language after 1100 qualifies as a romance.¹³⁹ Although the period when romance was perhaps most prolific was between 1150 to 1250, romances were written well into the fifteenth century.¹⁴⁰ The name, *romance*, came from the Latin *roman*, meaning vernacular; although it came to be understood as literature from France, where romances first emerged.¹⁴¹ The rise of romances was tied to literacy expanding beyond the clergy, who wrote almost exclusively in Latin, to the noble and middle classes, who wanted literature in their native or vernacular languages.¹⁴² “As the idea of vernacular literacy takes root and becomes institutionalized, functional, practical literacy in the vernaculars spreads to the noble, merchant, and political classes, and with it, the audience for written forms of vernacular verse.”¹⁴³ By the 15th century, members of these secular upper classes were commissioning anthologies of romances and other vernacular literature known as “grete books.”¹⁴⁴ Aside from

¹³⁸ Jay Ruud, “medieval romance.” In *Encyclopedia of Medieval Literature*, by Jay Ruud. 2nd ed. Facts On File, 2014.

http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/fofmedieval/medieval_romance/0?institutionId=288

¹³⁹ John Finlay, “Definitions of Middle English Romance” *The Chaucer Review* 15, no. 1 (1980), 45. www.jstor.org/stable/25093739.

¹⁴⁰ A.B. Taylor, *An Introduction to Medieval Romance*, (London, Heath Cranton Limited: 1971), 7.

¹⁴¹ S.G. Heller, “Medieval Romance.” In *The Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, edited by Roland Green, Stephen Cushman, and Clare Cavanagh. 4th ed. Princeton University Press, 2012. http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/prpoetry/medieval_romance/0?institutionId=288

¹⁴² C.W. Jones and T.V.F Brogan et al, “Medieval Poetry.” In *The Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, edited by Roland Green, Stephen Cushman, and Clare Cavanagh. 4th ed. Princeton University Press, 2012. http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/prpoetry/medieval_poetry/0?institutionId=288

¹⁴³ Jones and Brogan, et al. “Medieval Poetry” in *The Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*.

¹⁴⁴ Nigel Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, (Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press, 2011), 305.

being written in the common language, romances set themselves apart by being almost purely recreational, meant to entertain rather than impart a lesson on its reader.¹⁴⁵ The chief patrons of recreational literature were the women of the noble classes, who preferred more refinement in their poetry than had been in previous genres.¹⁴⁶ In fact, Chretien de Troyes patron for his *Lancelot* is Countess Marie of Champagne, daughter of Eleanor of Aquitaine.¹⁴⁷

The genre of romance evolved from the older *chansons de geste*, literally “songs of great deeds”, these stories were focused on war and valor and are sometimes described as epic poems.¹⁴⁸ Of the chansons, one of the most famous is also one of the earliest: *The Song of Roland*, written around 1100, which tells the story of a knight in Charlemagne’s army in a war against “sinful pagans”.¹⁴⁹ These poems did not shy away from depicting violence, the hero of *The Song of Roland*, towards the end of the poem is described as having suffered a blow “which brake his temple’s veins,” and eventually caused “out his ears his brains [to] runneth forth.”¹⁵⁰ The *chansons de geste* placed emphasis on martial strength and brutality, feudal loyalty, and religious piety as the essential virtues of the hero; however in the romances a new emphasis was placed on courtly manners, love affairs and the adventures of the individual hero independently.¹⁵¹ However, the romance was also a departure from the *chanson de geste* in that it

¹⁴⁵ Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, 46.

¹⁴⁶ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 60.

¹⁴⁷ Chrétien de Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, (London: Penguin Books, 2004), 270

¹⁴⁸ Jay Ruud, “chanson de geste.” In *Encyclopedia of Medieval Literature*, by Jay Ruud. 2nd ed. Facts On File, 2014.

http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/fofmedieval/chanson_de_geste/0?institutionId=288

¹⁴⁹ “Roland.” In *The Bloomsbury Dictionary of English Literature*, ed. Marion Wynne-Davies. 2nd ed. Bloomsbury, 1997.

<http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/blit/roland/0?institutionId=288>

¹⁵⁰ Dorothy L. Sayers, *The Song of Roland*, (New York: Penguin Books, 1957.) 132, 138.

¹⁵¹ Ruud, “medieval romance” in *Encyclopedia of Medieval Literature*.

reflected the audience and the new chivalric culture which developed around the 12th century, particularly codified with the writings of Chretien de Troyes in the 1170's.¹⁵²

The knights and their women were the main consumers of these tales.¹⁵³ Romances did not lose the violent edge present in the *chansons*; for example, Chretien de Troyes's *Erec et Enide* has multiple graphic scenes of violence. One example from the romance reads: "...Erec thrust the finely made, keen-edged iron into his [the knight's] throat beneath the chin; he sliced through all the bones and nerves, and the iron burst out the other side."¹⁵⁴ This demonstrates that the romances had not lost the ferocity of the *chansons*, but added a veneer of pageantry and courtliness that defined the genre.¹⁵⁵ Historian Nigel Saul says that "romance, in a sense was an inevitable accompaniment to war: when the pain and suffering of conflict were so great, it provided an element of glamour which made the suffering seem worthwhile."¹⁵⁶ Medieval romance was a genre of literature that tried to define knighthood in terms like chivalry, placing an equal emphasis on the nonviolent aspects of knighthood as the earlier *chansons* had on the violent aspects.¹⁵⁷ The romances were less about expressing the heroic ideals and instead expressing the ideals of the aristocratic class the heroes came from.¹⁵⁸

Romance has been credited by historian John Frederick Rowbotham as the "most important of all the forms of composition cultivated by the troubadours."¹⁵⁹ The troubadours were composers or authors hired by noble courts, although modern historians have ascribed the

¹⁵² Ruud, "medieval romance" in *The Encyclopedia of Medieval Literature*.

¹⁵³ Keen, *Chivalry*, 30.

¹⁵⁴ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 74.

¹⁵⁵ Keen, *Chivalry*, 109.

¹⁵⁶ Nigel Saul, *Age of Chivalry: Art and Society in Late Medieval England*, (London: Brockhampton Press: 1995), 16.

¹⁵⁷ Keen, *Chivalry*, 2.

¹⁵⁸ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 8.

¹⁵⁹ John Frederick Rowbotham, *The Troubadours and Courts of Love*, (Detroit, MI: Singing Tree Press, 1969), 90.

term to a specific class of poet, this was not the case in the middle ages.¹⁶⁰ “In medieval France, they [the terms troubadour and the northern *trouvere*] could be applied to anyone who wrote or composed anything at all, lyric or narrative, with or without music.”¹⁶¹ The troubadours flourished after the end of the first crusade in the 12th century, they were inspired by the “civilized court and castle life” they worked in.¹⁶² According to medievalist Frances Gies, “The troubadour was a knightly poet. He wrote for and about knights.”¹⁶³ However, Troubadours were not exclusively men, in fact, the noblewomen who were patrons for the troubadours themselves could be poets; these *trobairitz* as they have been called are largely dismissed as amateurs in comparison to their male equivalents, which is an incorrect assumption.¹⁶⁴ Marie de France, a contemporary of De Troyes and an author of English short romances or *lais*, who wrote for the court of Henry II in the 1170’s credited her stories as translations of earlier troubadour poems.¹⁶⁵ In the introduction of her lai *Equitan*, Marie de France said that she isn’t the originator of the story but rather that she “heard recited” from Breton sources.¹⁶⁶

The romances however, included themes not found in previous literature, specifically ideas of courtly love and chivalry, which were meant to appeal to the noblewomen commissioning the earliest romances.¹⁶⁷ According to medievalist Nigel Saul, “In the writings of the twelfth-century troubadours and lyric poets we find the first stirrings of a sensuous new

¹⁶⁰ L. M. Wright, “Misconceptions concerning the Troubadours, Trouvères and Minstrels.” *Music & Letters* 48, no. 1 (1967): 38 Accessed March 3, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/733150.

¹⁶¹ Wright, “Misconceptions concerning the Troubadours,” 38,39.

¹⁶² Gies, *The Knight in History*, 48.

¹⁶³ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 51.

¹⁶⁴ Matilda Tomaryn Bruckner. “Fictions of the Female Voice: The Women Troubadours.” *Speculum* 67, no. 4 (1992): 866. Accessed February 13, 2020. doi:10.2307/2863471.

¹⁶⁵ Jay Ruud, “lay.” In *Encyclopedia of Medieval Literature*, by Jay Ruud. 2nd ed. Facts On File, 2014. <http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/fofmedieval/lai/0?institutionId=288>

¹⁶⁶ Marie de France, *The Lais of Marie de France*, trans. Keith Busby and Glyn S. Burgess (London: Penguin Books, 2003.),56

¹⁶⁷ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 60.

mood. Love and the amorous desires of the heart were for the first time treated as central to the poetic vision.”¹⁶⁸ English literature historian A. B. Taylor credited Chretien de Troyes in particular with having “established courtly love and chivalry as the enduring themes” of romance literature.¹⁶⁹ The term courtly love was coined in 1881 by Gaston Paris to describe an innocent yet illicit kind of relationship that adhered to a complex set of rules, based on the affair of Lancelot and Guinevere described by de Troyes.¹⁷⁰

The relationship exemplified in *Lancelot* was codified by Andreas Cappellanus’s treatise on love around 1200, based on “Ars Amoria” by the Roman poet Ovid.¹⁷¹ Cappellanius worked under Marie de Champagne, the same patron as de Troyes, and cites the countess as an expert on love.¹⁷² In his treatise, Capellanus defines love as “a certain inborn suffering derived from the sight of and excessive meditation upon the beauty of the opposite sex, which causes each one to wish above all things the embraces of the other and by common desire to carry out love’s precepts in the other’s embrace.”¹⁷³ He says that this kind of love is only reserved for the nobility and says that peasants are incapable of love, and it is unnatural for them and that it distracts them from working on their farms.¹⁷⁴ There are additional rules that Capellanus says are essential for

¹⁶⁸ Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, 263.

¹⁶⁹ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 61.

¹⁷⁰ Michael Bryson, and Arpi Movsesian. "The Troubadours and Fin'amor: Love, Choice, and the Individual." In *Love and Its Critics: From the Song of Songs to Shakespeare and Milton's Eden*, 123. (Cambridge, UK: Open Book Publishers, 2017.) Accessed February 20, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1sq5vd6.8.

¹⁷¹ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 238.

¹⁷² Bernard O'Donoghue, *The Courtly Love Tradition*, (Manchester, UK: Manchester University Press, 1982,) 38.

¹⁷³ Andreas Capellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, trans. by John Jay Parry, (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 1990,) 28.

¹⁷⁴ Capellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, 149.

fin d'amour or “true love”: that love exists outside of marriage, the lover was supposedly beholden to his lady and that a lover will be made a nobler person by love.^{175 176}

Lancelot, or, *The Knight of the Cart*, is one of the most enduring examples of courtly love, as it was centered on an adulterous affair that became the basis for the term courtly love.¹⁷⁷ In the romance, Lancelot dishonored himself by climbing into a prison cart in order to find Queen Guinevere and rescue her.¹⁷⁸ De Troyes says that climbing into the cart would be a disgrace, but he also says that “because Love ordered and wished it, he jumped in; since Love ruled his action the disgrace did not matter.”¹⁷⁹ De Troyes focused on this tension between reason and passion as a main theme of *Lancelot*, and perhaps as literary expert Fanni Bogdanow suggests, a criticism of courtly love.¹⁸⁰ When he and Guinevere are reunited, she dismisses him and Lancelot all but dies from grief and defends his actions, “whatever one might do for one’s sweetheart should be considered an act of love and courtliness.”¹⁸¹ This sentiment is repeated in *The Art of Courtly Love*, in which Capellanus said “no one does a good or courteous deed in the world unless it is derived from the fount of love.”¹⁸² As a courtly lover, Guinevere was Lancelot’s top priority, the key catalyst for all his subsequent actions in the romance.¹⁸³

In Marie de France’s lai *Lanval*, Guinevere propositioned another one of Arthur’s knights and when she is rejected he is put on trial by Arthur for insulting her.¹⁸⁴ Another example, in *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, Gawain’s hostess seduced him, saying that as “the embodiment

¹⁷⁵ O’ Donoghue, *The Courtly Love Tradition*, 312.

¹⁷⁶ Capellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, 7, 185,186.

¹⁷⁷ O’Donoghue, *The Courtly Love Tradition*, 166.

¹⁷⁸ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 209-210.

¹⁷⁹ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 212.

¹⁸⁰ Bogdanow, “The Love Theme In Chrétien de Troyes’s “Chevalier De La Charrette”.”, 61.

¹⁸¹ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 261

¹⁸² Capellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, 40.

¹⁸³ Jennifer G. Wollock, *Rethinking Chivalry and Courtly Love*.(Santa Barbara, CA: ABC-CLIO, 2011.), 126.

¹⁸⁴ De France, *The Lais of Marie de France*, 77.

of courtliness to the bones of his being,” the knight must want to kiss her.¹⁸⁵ The lady even faulted Sir Gawain for not having a mistress, because without love, Gawain lacked motivation and the height of chivalry.¹⁸⁶ De Troyes did not address the extra-marital nature of the affair in his *Lancelot*, but later authors, especially Sir Thomas Malory in his 1485 book *Le Morte D’Arthur*, certainly did.¹⁸⁷ Malory agreed that it is Lancelot’s relationship with Guinevere that inspired him to become a hero, but also made their affair the cause of Arthur’s eventual downfall.¹⁸⁸ According to medievalist Derek Brewer, “Lancelot does cause misfortune to all about him, because through him and Guinevere are the greatest king and flower of knights destroyed.”¹⁸⁹ In an earlier series of anonymous romances, the *Lancelot-Grail* or *Vulgate Cycle* written in the 1230’s, King Arthur almost puts Guinevere to death and declares war on Lancelot for their affair.¹⁹⁰ In Malory’s *Morte D’Arthur* the affair seems to be common knowledge but was described as shameful.¹⁹¹ According to Malory: “I marvel that we all be not ashamed to see and to know how Sir Lancelot lieth daily and nightly by the Queen...that we should suffer so noble a king as King Arthur is to be shamed.”¹⁹²

Courtly love as a concept developed in response to the strict religious doctrine around purity and chastity that were becoming more pronounced in the 12th century.¹⁹³ In the 1380’s the

¹⁸⁵ Simon Armitage, trans. *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* (London: W.W. Norton & Company, 2007.) 107.

¹⁸⁶ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 236.

¹⁸⁷ Lori J. Walters, ed. *Lancelot and Guinevere: A Casebook*. (New York, NY: Garland Publishing, 1996.), 61.

¹⁸⁸ Wollock, *Rethinking Chivalry and Courtly Love*, 146.

¹⁸⁹ Walters, ed. *Lancelot and Guinevere: A Casebook*, 21.

¹⁹⁰ Norris J. Lacy, ed. *The Lancelot-Grail Reader: Sections from the Medieval French Arthurian Cycle*. (New York, NY: Garland Publishing, 2000.), 379, 382.

¹⁹¹ Thomas Malory, *Le Morte Darthur: The Winchester Manuscript*, ed. By Helen Cooper, (Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press. 1998,) 469

¹⁹² Thomas Malory, *Le Morte Darthur: The Winchester Manuscript*, 468

¹⁹³ Jeffrey B. Russell, "Courtly Love as Religious Dissent." *The Catholic Historical Review* 51, no. 1 (1965): 42. Accessed March 2, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/25017609.

monk Thomas of Walsingham accused the knights of Richard II's court of being "Knights of Venus" and showing more prowess in bed than in battle.¹⁹⁴ Indeed in the later middle ages, particularly in the 15th and 16th centuries knighthood turned away from the courts of arms to the courts of love.¹⁹⁵ Adultery was permissible in men, but in women "cost a husband his honor" according to Gies, with the lovers often facing severe punishment.¹⁹⁶ This view is largely in line with Malory's *Morte D'Arthur*. The courtly love of the romances preached love at any cost. In Cappellanus, the lady becomes the lord, and her lover must submit to her.¹⁹⁷ Lancelot and other fictional courtly lovers were a sort of wish-fulfillment for the female audience; they represented passionate extramarital love that was impossible for this audience.¹⁹⁸ De Troyes in particular wrote for Marie de Champagne, who according to the introduction of Lancelot, specifically requested the element of courtly love be included.¹⁹⁹ Courtly love appears to have existed in literature rather than in reality.

Chivalry was the other important contribution of romance literature to medieval culture, however, the evidence of chivalry's impact was much clearer than courtly love's, especially among the military classes.²⁰⁰ What chivalry meant was hard to define, according to Saul: "Medieval chivalry was more an outlook than a doctrine, more a lifestyle than an explicit ethical code."²⁰¹ There were, however, some qualities that made one chivalrous according to the romances: prowess, loyalty, generosity, courtesy and a "free and frank bearing."²⁰² The concept

¹⁹⁴ W. M. Ormrod, "KNIGHTS OF VENUS." *Medium Aevum* 73, no. 2 (2004): 290, <http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.proquest.com/docview/194191424?accountid=14171>.

¹⁹⁵ Keen, *Chivalry*, 239.

¹⁹⁶ Gies, *The Knight In History*, 60.

¹⁹⁷ Cappellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, 7.

¹⁹⁸ Wollock, *Rethinking Chivalry and Courtly Love*, 126.

¹⁹⁹ Taylor, *Medieval Romance*, 236.

²⁰⁰ Keen, *Chivalry*, 239.

²⁰¹ Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, 3.

²⁰² Keen, *Chivalry*, 2.

of chivalry was the result of a transformation of the medieval army that placed mounted knights at the forefront, which built camaraderie and a sense of identity among them.²⁰³

In De Troyes's *Lancelot*, Gawain serves as a foil to Lancelot, the perfect courtly lover, by representing the perfect chivalric knight.²⁰⁴ Unlike Lancelot, Gawain refuses to board the cart as it would be too great a dishonor.²⁰⁵ The rest of De Troyes' romances neglect courtly love in favor of chivalry.²⁰⁶ In particular *Cliges* features all of the qualities of chivalry, the knight's father, Alexander demonstrates generosity he was "mindful of the emperor's exhortation and advice to have his heart ever ready to give and spend liberally."²⁰⁷ Later in the same romance, Alexander "showed largesse in the spilling of blood" as he and the other knights in King Arthur's court put down a rebellion by a traitorous Count.²⁰⁸ In *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, Gawain laments his failures as a knight in having "forgotten the fidelity and kindness every knight knows," when he took the girdle in secret from the hostess.²⁰⁹ However, Gawain is praised for his chivalry in part because of his "good cheer", even when facing death, he attempted to seem in good spirits.²¹⁰ In *Le Morte D'Arthur*, chivalry is secular, the knights of the round table are united in their loyalty to Arthur; they swore to abide by rules that forbade treason, emphasized mercy and never be involved in petty wars.²¹¹

²⁰³ Saul, *The Age of Chivalry*, 6.

²⁰⁴ Fanni Bogdanow. "The Love Theme in Chrétien De Troyes's "Chevalier De La Charrette"." *The Modern Language Review* 67, no. 1 (1972): 54. Accessed March 5, 2020. doi:10.2307/3722385.

²⁰⁵ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 212

²⁰⁶ Bogdanow, "The Love Theme in Chretien De Troyes" 50.

²⁰⁷ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 128

²⁰⁸ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 144.

²⁰⁹ Armitage, *Gawain and the Green Knight*, 179.

²¹⁰ T. A. Shippey. "The Uses of Chivalry: "Erec" and "Gawain"." *The Modern Language Review* 66, no. 2 (1971): 247. Accessed March 1, 2020. doi:10.2307/3722880.

²¹¹ Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, 314-315.

Paradoxically, despite Malory's knights of the round table vowing to defend women, Malory, also a knight, was accused of *raptus* against a woman known as Joan Smith.²¹² *Raptus*, in medieval legal documents was a term used to describe "sexual assault, forcible abduction, or consensual departure," although Malory was accused of having assaulted Smith.²¹³ Medieval society, particularly among the knightly classes, was violent; war had an almost constant presence which led to pervasive violence in medieval culture.²¹⁴ According to Saul, "violent, aggressive behaviour was a feature of the disputes that knights engaged in over land and status as much as it was of their conduct in arms."²¹⁵ One letter from a knight simply known as Guy dating to 1249 describes the "exquisite tortures [through] we extracted the truth from the sailors who fell alive into our hands."²¹⁶

Chivalry was based on an aristocratic sense of honor.²¹⁷ The knight, in order to be considered honorable or chivalrous, had to be willing to defend the faith and his lord, while also governing his own lands.²¹⁸ Being willing to defend the faith made chivalry part of the language of the crusades and according to medievalist Maurice Keen, "brought church authorities, and in particular the reformed papacy of the late eleventh century, to terms with war and the warrior's place in society."²¹⁹ The church had made an attempt to create, or at least promote, a code of

²¹² Caroline Dunn, "The Language of Ravishment in Medieval England." *Speculum* 86, no. 1 (2011): 91. Accessed March 2, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/41105501.

²¹³ Dunn, "The Language of Ravishment," 90

²¹⁴ Sean McGlynn, "Pueri Sunt Pueri: Machismo, Chivalry, and the Aggressive Pastimes of the Medieval Male Youth." *Historical Reflections / Réflexions Historiques* 42, no. 1 (2016): 89. Accessed March 7, 2020. www.jstor.org/stable/24720618.

²¹⁵ Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, 181.

²¹⁶ Dana C. Munro, trans. "Medieval Sourcebook: Guy, A Knight: Letter from the Sixth Crusade, 1249." Internet History Sourcebooks Project. Last modified January 26, 1996. <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/1249sixthcde-let.asp>.

²¹⁷ Saul, *Chivalry in Medieval England*, 187.

²¹⁸ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 105.

²¹⁹ Keen, *Chivalry*, 49.

chivalry albeit one that was more likely to be disobeyed than followed.²²⁰ The “Truce of God” in 1063, just thirty years before the First Crusade, attempted to put limits on violence creating a specific period of peace, from Wednesday to Monday, during which any act of violence would be punished.²²¹ The Crusades made an exception to this rule, and provided the crusader with many earthly benefits.²²²

All of the heroes of medieval romances were noblemen, so it is no surprise that nobility was one of the chief values of chivalry.²²³ From the thirteenth century onwards there was a new emphasis on the lineage of the knights, especially in terms of nobility and heraldry.²²⁴ Heraldry referred to the distinctive insignias, coats of arms and other markers on shields and banners which denoted lineage or identity.²²⁵ In *Etablissements de Saint Louis*, a legal text dating to 1270, knighthood in France was inherited from the father’s own knighthood.²²⁶ The term chivalry now not only applied to those formally knighted but, according to Keen “it also comes to be used to describe the obligations, estate, and style of life of those entitled, on account of their birth, to aspire to knighthood.”²²⁷ This is a sharp contrast to De Troyes’s knight Alexander, who chooses to abandon his hereditary knighthood in order to seek knighthood from King Arthur “in order to learn honor.”²²⁸

²²⁰ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 2.

²²¹ “Truce of God - Bishopric of Terouanne, 1063.” Internet History Sourcebooks Project. Last modified January 26, 1996. <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/t-of-god.asp>.

²²² Gies, *The Knight in History*, 35.

²²³ Finlay, “Definitions of Middle English Romance”, 45.

²²⁴ Keen, *Chivalry*, 143.

²²⁵ Anne Curry, “heraldry.” In *The Oxford Companion to British History*, edited by John Cannon, and Robert Crowcroft. 2nd ed. (Oxford:Oxford University Press., 2015.) <http://ezproxy.purchase.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/oupoxford/heraldry/0?institutionId=288>

²²⁶ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 103.

²²⁷ Keen, *Chivalry*, 145.

²²⁸ De Troyes, *Arthurian Romances*, 124.

Conclusion

When one pictures the medieval knight, they imagine a dashing hero in a suit of armor rescuing damsels, a man who adheres to a strict moral code of mercy and honor. This knight is less a character of history but rather a fiction, a character passed down through centuries of romance literature. . During the Middle Ages King Arthur, and more often his knights, were the subject of hundreds of romances. They were so ingrained in medieval pop culture that one of Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales* is an Arthurian romance.²²⁹ The Arthur of romance was the height of chivalry, and the representation of knighthood presented in these romances became our modern standard.²³⁰

The knights of medieval romance were often roaming knights-errant, but they are still shown to ultimately be loyal to their liege, in many cases the legendary King Arthur. Arthur, to the medieval imagination, was the greatest of all British kings, the legendary ancestor to England's monarchy.²³¹ Arthur was a cultural icon for Medieval Britain, and he appeared in writings beginning in at least the 9th century.²³² By the twelfth century, when romance literature was in its most prolific period, the legend had flowered with the writings of French poet Chretien de Troyes.²³³ Arthur and his knights were written to be the pinnacle of chivalry, meant to serve as examples for members of the knightly class.²³⁴ Through Arthuriana, knighthood took on a new desirable identity, with even kings seeking knighthood.²³⁵ With the end of the Middle Ages,

²²⁹ Chaucer, *The Canterbury Tales*, trans. David Wright, 240.

²³⁰ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 75.

²³¹ Flood, "Arthur's Return to Avalon," 84-86

²³² Wiseman, "The Derivation of the Date of the Badon Entry", 2

²³³ Ashe, "A Certain Very Ancient Book", 323

²³⁴ Gies, *The Knight in History*, 75.

²³⁵ Keen, *Chivalry*, 68

Arthur fell to the sidelines, only to be revived by the Victorians. In particular art and poetry movements like the Pre-Raphaelites made people nostalgic for the medieval period as presented in Arthuriana.²³⁶ Arthuriana became more than a representation of a particular class and a symbol for England as a nation.²³⁷ But the romantic representation of medieval history as shown through Arthuriana created a nostalgic and idealized past and with it, a romantic image of the knight.²³⁸

In this paper, I have argued that the real knights of the Middle Ages were noble in terms of heritage rather than ideals, that chivalry was practiced as a culture of knighthood as a warrior and aristocratic class and not an ethical code of behavior.²³⁹ Chivalry was a principal that was based more on warfare and aristocracy than in religious morality. The knight of medieval romance was the result of the patronage of noblewomen and knights aggrandizing their chivalric identity.^{240 241} The chivalry of romances was concerned with mercy, and in particular the protection of women. But even the author of one of the most famous interpretations of the Arthurian legend failed to live up to this standard, writing his book while in prison for assault. On crusade, another knight described with excitement torturing his enemy, while in romances from the same time knights were applauded for their mercy.²⁴² This was the knight of history, a warrior and a landowner, not the courtly lover and jousting seen in the romances of Chrétien de Troyes.

²³⁶ "Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood." In the Thames & Hudson Dictionary of British Art.

²³⁷ Higham, King Arthur, 36

²³⁸ Haught, "Performing Nostalgia: Medievalism in 'King Arthur'", 121

²³⁹ Douglas, "Knighthood as it Was."

²⁴⁰ Taylor, Medieval Romance, 60

²⁴¹ Dunn, "The Language of Ravishment in Medieval England." 91

²⁴² Dana C. Munro, trans. "Medieval Sourcebook: Guy, A Knight: Letter from the Sixth Crusade, 1249." Internet History Sourcebooks Project. Last modified January 26, 1996. <https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/source/1249sixthcde-let.asp>.

Arthuriana, and romances writ large, survived because they were entertaining, but they also show us how knights wished to be seen. The troubadours who composed the romances were often writing for knights, and they created a knight that was ideal. All of the accoutrements of chivalry, the heraldry, tournaments and indeed romances themselves were created by the knighthood as a means to explain and incentivise the violence inherent in warfare. Lancelot endures as our archetypal knight not because he represented reality, but because he was the archetype knights wanted to see in themselves and their traditions. In the 13th century, kings put on elaborate round-table tournaments, where knights cast themselves as romance heroes.²⁴³ In essence, I believe romances didn't represent knighthood as it was, but instead as the knights themselves saw it. _____

²⁴³ Kline, "The Influence of Romances on Tournaments of the Middle Ages.", 204.

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